# 2.3 French and Dutch Colonies

If you visit a coffee shop in Burlington, Vermont, you might see a menu that has both French and English descriptions. Walk around New York City and you'll see Dutch names for streets. Different languages and names are the remnants of European exploration in the 17th century.

**MAIN IDEA** The French and Dutch claimed North American lands as rich sources of trade and wealth, but they had trouble establishing colonies.

## OUTPOSTS IN NEW FRANCE

In 1608, explorer and cartographer **Samuel de Champlain** established a fur-trading base at a point along the St. Lawrence River that became the first permanent French settlement in North America. For two decades, Champlain explored the **watershed** lands, or the area drained by rivers, surrounding his post. As he explored, he strengthened trading ties with the Huron, the Algonquian, and the Montagnai. Champlain also allied with these Native Americans against the Iroquois. Champlain's new trading partners brought him valuable furs, which he then shipped to Europe to be sold. Hearing of Champlain's success, other French traders joined him. This system resulted in an international fur trade so robust the country claimed the region, naming it **New France**.

Population growth in New France was slow. Twenty years after Champlain began his business, the post, which was later named Quebec (kuh-BEK), was home to only about 100 people. By comparison, Jamestown, Virginia, grew from 105 people at its founding in 1607 to 1,240 people in 1622.

In an effort to encourage French people to settle in New France, Champlain's company expanded its charter to include lands from Florida to the Arctic. The company sent Jesuit priests to Native American villages in the hope of learning their languages and converting them to Christianity in accordance with France's Catholic beliefs. However, the French government's refusal to allow Protestants, the most likely immigrants, to settle in the Americas kept the outposts' populations small.

Another factor limiting population growth in New France was its social structure. France was still a feudal society, and settlers brought this system to the Western Hemisphere. Large manors belonged to wealthy settlers. All others worked as tenant farmers. Peasants living in France saw little chance to improve their status in the Americas, where they still could not own and work their own land.

## CONFLICT IN NEW NETHERLAND

As you have read, Henry Hudson was searching for a passage to Asia through North America when he discovered the river that would bear his name in what is today New York State. On behalf of the Dutch, Hudson sailed up the river, trading European knives and beads for furs from the Native Americans. The pelts brought a good price in Holland, the Dutch homeland, which is also known as the Netherlands. Traders responded by setting up a post near Albany, New York. In 1614, the Dutch built **Fort Nassau** in that same area. Like the French, the Dutch cooperated with local tribes to establish a thriving fur trade, and the colony of **New Netherland** was established.

The Dutch purchased the island of Manhattan from Native Americans in 1626. They developed the community of New Amsterdam, named for the capital of the Netherlands, but there was a misunderstanding. The Native Americans believed they had sold rights to share the land and could continue using it themselves. The Dutch believed they had purchased exclusive rights to the land. By 1640, the Dutch and the Native Americans were at war over the misunderstanding.



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AMERICAN PLACES

## Manhattan, New York

Long before skyscrapers towered above its shores, members of the Lenape tribe lived on this island at the mouth of the Hudson River. They called it Mannahatta, "the island of many hills." Compare and contrast the two views of Manhattan shown below. The photo on top is a computer model that suggests what the island might have looked like when Henry Hudson arrived in 1609. The photo at the bottom shows Manhattan 400 years later, in 2009. Manhattan is a borough of New York City, which is the largest city by population in the United States.



The conflict over Manhattan represented a larger issue. Native American tribes, such as the Abenaki and Powhatan, had been living in eastern North America for centuries before Europeans arrived. English settlements in New England and near Chesapeake Bay were agricultural societies, while the French, Dutch, and Swedes focused on trade. Conflicts over land arose between Europeans and Native Americans in these areas. Different European groups sometimes involved Native American trading partners in their arguments over trading opportunities. Some disputes ended in violence. Additionally, many Native Americans succumbed to European diseases, resulting in a decrease in their populations.

### HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did explorers influence international trade during the 17th century?
2. **FORM AND SUPPORT OPINIONS** In your opinion, what could the French have done differently to attract settlers and grow the population of New France? Support your opinion with evidence from the text.
3. **INTERPRET VISUALS** What physical features might have made Mannahatta an attractive place for the Dutch to build a community?



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